

Flu virus gets second wind, bringing more misery

Concerns raised that it could help bird flu mutate

By Kay Lazar
GLOBE STAFF

The flu is walloping every corner of Massachusetts in an unusual second surge of the season, with people reporting flu-like symptoms at rates higher than any other winter peak since before COVID struck five years ago, according to state data.

Nationally, as well as across the state, flu peaked in early January, headed back down, and then abruptly spiked again. Now, federal data show respiratory illnesses are elevated nationwide and are continuing to climb, prompting some to worry influenza might even help the rapidly spreading bird flu virus to mutate and become more infectious among humans.

In Massachusetts, the latest numbers show that more than 10 percent of patients dragging themselves into doctors offices are suffering from fevers, coughs, and sore throats, classic flu symptoms. But because many don't end up getting tested, the actual rate of infections may be substantially higher, doctors said.

By comparison, usually about about 6 or 7 percent of doctor visits during the peak of flu season are linked to the virus, state data show.

"Its like a tsunami right now," said Dr. Sandeep Jubbil, an infectious diseases specialist at UMass Memorial Medical Center in Worcester.

Jubbil noted that waste water surveillance for a large swath of Eastern Massachusetts shows COVID-19 and RSV, another respiratory virus, also peaked in early January but both have dropped significantly since then.

Even norovirus, that nasty stomach bug that seemed to be hitting nearly every family just a few weeks ago, is also starting to wane, the waste water numbers show.

But the flu virus is still on the way up. "It's keeping all the other respiratory viruses at bay," Jubbil said. "It's always a competition."

FLU, Page A10

Cambridge opens door for housing by building up

By Andrew Brinker
GLOBE STAFF

The Cambridge City Council on Monday night passed a dramatic overhaul of the city's land-use rules, broadly allowing buildings up to six stories in neighborhoods across the city.

The plan makes Cambridge one of the first cities in the state to eliminate single-family zoning, meaning there's no longer anyplace in the city where only single-family homes can be built. That has long been the standard in many communities, but has greatly constricted the construction of housing. That does not mean single-family homes are no longer allowed in those neighborhoods, but rather that something as tall as six stories could be built on nearly any lot.

Under the new policy, any lot in the city, whether it now has a small, pastel-colored row house or sprawling mansion on it, can be redeveloped into a four-story apartment building without needing special city approval. Developers can add an additional two stories by-right if 20 percent of the units in a project are set aside as affordable and the lot meets a minimum size requirement.

Supporters hope the change will generate thousands of new units over the next decade in what is already one of the most densely populated — and most expensive — cities in the country.

"I think that this will be a landmark moment, where the zoning map of Cambridge doesn't exactly look like a copy . . . of a redlining map, where the [most] affordable housing is not only in areas which also have more people of color and more multifamily housing in general, but our whole city is growing together."

CAMBRIDGE, Page A10

Netanyahu warns on cease-fire

A LOSS FOR FREEZE

A federal appeals court refused to halt a judge's order requiring the Trump administration to release billions of dollars in federal grants and loans.

States say the money remains frozen even after the judge blocked a sweeping pause. The Boston-based First US Circuit Court of Appeals turned back the administration's emergency appeal. **A6.**

POPE SPEAKS OUT ON DEPORTATIONS

Pope Francis harshly criticized President Trump's policy of mass deportations and urged Catholics to reject anti-immigrant narratives in an unusually direct attack on the Trump administration.



DATA MUST BE RESTORED

The Trump administration was ordered by a federal judge to restore some material that was purged from government websites under the president's executive orders on gender while a legal challenge from a physicians group proceeds. The judge said officials probably violated federal law in removing the scientific data.

BANNON GUILTY

Steve Bannon, a longtime adviser to Trump, pleaded guilty in Manhattan criminal court to a single count of defrauding donors who sought to help build a wall at the southern border. **A6.**



MUSK AT THE WHITE HOUSE

The president appeared with Elon Musk on Tuesday before signing an executive order to continue downsizing the federal workforce. "The people voted for major government reform and that's what the people are going to get," Musk said. "That's what democracy is all about." **A6.**

JIM WATSON/AFP
VIA GETTY IMAGES

Researchers at a loss over 'assault on science'

By Chris Serres, Liz Kowalczyk, and Neena Hagen
GLOBE STAFF

Dr. Celeste Royce was preparing to address a class of Harvard Medical School students last week when she learned, via email, that a study she wrote on endometriosis had vanished from a government website as part of a sweeping purge by the Trump administration of health research seen as promoting "gender ideology."

Stunned, Royce struggled to comprehend why a study about an often-painful condition afflicting nearly 1 in 10 women and girls had become a target. Then she found the likely reason: A brief mention of "trans and non-gender-conforming" people in the final paragraph of the study.

"My jaw dropped," said Royce, a Harvard Medical School assistant professor. "It was a clear case of censorship."

Days earlier, Jaclyn White Hughto felt a similar shock when a federal agency ordered her to cease all research activities that promote "gender ideology." Hughto and her research team are conducting a long-running study of fatal drug overdoses, but the edict threw her into a panic because her study includes transgender people.

"Any study that uses the wrong words is

RESEARCHERS, Page A7

USAID



'It basically gave the entire industry a collective heart attack. We never envisioned that the federal government would

systematically not pay us.'

STEVE SCHMIDA, cofounder of Resonance Global

MORE ON USAID, A6.

After stripping of USAID, disbelief and unpaid bills

By Nick Stoico
GLOBE STAFF

When President Trump, on the first day of his second term, signed an executive order suspending all US foreign assistance programs for 90 days, Steve Schmida wasn't too worried.

The cofounder of a Vermont-based consulting firm and longtime contractor with the US Agency for International Development, Schmida felt the move could be "a little disruptive, but nothing catastrophic" for him and his staff at Resonance Global, which has worked around the world promoting economic growth and innovation, environmental sustainability, food security, and other projects.

In its 20 years, the firm had weathered similar pauses before, he noted.

But later that week, Schmida's team heard from a source inside USAID that the agency's accounting system had been shut down. That same day, the State Department issued a sweeping stop-work order on aid projects.

"It basically gave the entire industry a collective heart attack," he said. "We never envisioned that the federal government would systematically not pay us."

The Trump administration's decision to dismantle the independent agency, which

USAID, Page A7



More than a game

The Bosse pickleball complex at the Natick Mall features four culinary concepts, including Bosse Enoteca, which allows you to eat behind glass while watching the players (or vice versa). **G1.**

A federal court dismissed a lawsuit over Massachusetts' automotive right-to-repair law, possibly paving the way for it to take effect. **B5.**

The state's highest court ruled that there were no serious issues with the declaration of a mistrial in the Karen Read case last summer, clearing a hurdle for the upcoming retrial. **B1.**

Having a meltdown

Wednesday: Sunny, chilly. High 32-37. Low 29-34.

Thursday: Rain, warmer. High 46-51. Low 21-26.

Weather and Comics, G6-7.

VOL. 307, NO. 43

Suggested retail price
\$4.00



0 947725 4